

PANKAJ NANGIA



Blast from the Past

CHANDIGARH The past seldom fails to catch up with politicians. Former Haryana chief minister and leader of the Opposition in the state Om Prakash Chautala knows it only too well. The CBI has indicted the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) supremo and his son and Rajya Sabha member Ajay Chautala in the JBT schoolteachers' recruitment scandal that

had rocked the previous INLD government.

In a damning report submitted to the Supreme Court, CBI, on the basis of its four-year-long probe, has charged the Chautalas and 21 Haryana government officials, including two IAS officers, under the Prevention of Corruption Act and for tampering with official records.

The genesis of the scandal lies in the selec-

CAUGHT IN A WEB: Om Prakash (left) and Ajay Chautala were indicted for the recruitment of 3,000 schoolteachers in 1999 by the Bansi Lal government before it was toppled by Chautala who, upon coming to power, reportedly forced officials to tamper with the original recruitment list to favour many who were not selected initially. An IAS officer blew the whistle on the bungling and moved the Supreme Court, which ordered a CBI probe in 2003.

The bureau has now sought the permission from the Rajya Sabha and the Haryana Assembly to prosecute the Chautalas who are facing another CBI probe into a disproportionate assets case. Chautala senior is also facing the heat on dubious Haryana Civil Service appointments made during his tenure as the case is under the scanner of the Punjab and Haryana High Court.

The INLD chief, who has joined the fledgling Third Front at the national level to regain his political ground, can expect some more blasts from the past.

by Ramesh Vinayak

SIGNPOSTS

SENTENCED: To life imprisonment, **Abdul Latif, Deepak Bhujail and Yusuf Nepali**, accused in the hijacking of Kathmandu-Delhi Indian Airlines flight IC-814 to Kandahar, Afghanistan, in December 1999. They were convicted by a special court in Patiala.

DIED: **Russy K. Karanjia**, 95, journalist and the former editor of *Blitz*, the first Indian weekly tabloid, which he founded in 1941.



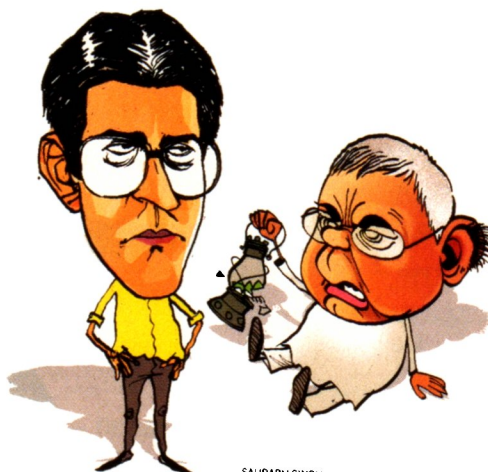
WON: By pugilist **Akhil Kumar**, 27, the gold medal (54 kg) in the Asian Olympic Boxing tournament in Bangkok, beating Worapoj Petchkoom of Thailand.

APPOINTED: **A.S. Gill**, DGP Rajasthan, as the director-general of the NHRC.

DIED: Malayalam actor **Bharat Gopi**, 71. He made his debut in 1972 and was awarded the Padmashree in 1991.

VIS-A-VIS **RAJ THACKERAY** Maharashtra Navnirman Sena leader **versus** **LALU PRASAD YADAV** Union Railway Minister

If north Indians want to stay in Maharashtra, then they better learn the Marathi culture and language.



Raj Thackeray is using regionalism to split the country. He should observe Chhath to keep his own mind cool.

EPILOGUE: Stuck in the narrow lanes of regionalism, when will our politicians embrace nationalism?